HONEY, I SHRUNK THE SUV!



A COMPACT, AFFORDABLE CAR THAT TICKS ALL THE BOXES OF THE INCREASINGLY POPULAR SUV SEGMENT. IT LOOKS LIKE A WINNING PACKAGE. THE EXTER IS A DECLARATION OF HYUNDAI'S INTENT TO DOMINATE THIS CATEGORY IN INDIA

BY DHRUV SAXENA

SUVs are what buyers want. They are driving growth across segments, and affordable small cars have been driving volumes in the Indian market. As Tata has proved with the Punch, there is scope for smaller and thus more affordable options. To cash in on that demand and go after Tata's almost unchallenged presence in that space, Hyundai has introduced the Exter.

Exter's height, upright stance, flat nose, body cladding and 185 mm ground clearance help reinforce its positioning as an SUV, albeit a very compact one. Hyundai's new design philosophy brings with it several distinctive elements like the H-shape LED DRLs (daylight running lamps) and the car's name spelt out on the nose. Like the DRLs up front, the tail lamps, too, get an H-shaped LED signature.

There's a fully digital instrument cluster on offer, as well as an eight-inch touchscreen offered in all trims except the base. Top-end trims of the Exter get features like automatic climate control, electrically adjustable and folding ORVMs, automatic headlamps, a sunroof, wireless phone charger, type C charging port, power windows, BlueLink connected car features, tyre pressure monitoring system, dashcam, reverse parking camera with sensors, and more. The generous height and wheelbase make the cabin feel airy, and the space is impressive too for a car this size. The rear seat scores high in terms of leg room, knee room and headroom, as well as underthigh support; the seat itself is quite comfortable. Passengers seated here get aircon vents and a 12V socket, but no USB port and no